

Can you believe it? It's summer, the landscape is green and beautiful, the weather is becoming rather warm, the kids are out of school, vacations are just around the corner and all of us seem to have more to do than we can say grace over. Summer is a wonderful time, however it can also be a tough time for Church attendance and finances. I hope that you and your family enjoy some quality time together but please remember to be faithful to your Church throughout the summer months.

REVIVAL JUNE 7-10

Kulman and Rita Lackey will be our evangelists for this revival crusade. Make plans now to attend every service. The Lackey's primary ministry seems to be to those who need to be baptized in the Holy Spirit. There will be prayer for people to receive the Holy Spirit in each service. Come **EXPECTING TO RECEIVE**.

MEMBERSHIP CLASSES

Membership classes will begin on Sunday May 31st, and continue through Sunday June 21st. The starting time for these classes will be 5:30 PM, each Sunday evening. The location for the class will be upstairs in the Education Building, the first door on the left. Attendance at these classes is mandatory for anyone who would like to join the Church.

Membership Sunday will be Sunday June 28th, 10:30 am. Remember, Church membership is of ultimate importance, we can't have a **CH RCH WITHOUT U!**

GUEST SPEAKERS LARRY AND JUDY MOORE

On Sunday July 19th former Pastors Larry and Judy Moore will be speaking in both the morning and evening services. Please put this date on your calendar and be present for this time of reunion, and excellent preaching.

BUILDING FUND

The new Church property has recently been bush hogged, and excavation has begun! The excitement is growing! Become a part of this dream being fulfilled! Make a commitment on a weekly, monthly, or annual basis. We need everyone to pull together in this effort. To make a contribution, mark your offering envelope, **BUILDING FUND**.

YOU ARE LOVED

Susan, the children and I would like you to know that we Love and appreciate each of you. If there is ever anything that I or any member of this staff can do to help you please do not hesitate to call on us. I can identify with the song writer who penned, "I'm so glad I'm a part of the family of God," without doubt this is truly the greatest Church family in the world!

GOD BLESS YOU AND CAUSE HIS FACE TO SHINE UPON YOU!

THE PROOF OF DESIRE IS PURSUIT

Over the past couple of years a renewed “DESIRE” for the things of God has become topic number one among the church crowd in America, and quite possibly worldwide. As I consider the idea of “DESIRE” for God, I must honestly ask myself what I am willing to surrender in order that I might “PURSUE” him and his righteousness. No one will ever be able to “PURSUE” the things of God as long as the influence of the world is important to them. The influence of the world is certainly worldliness, and sinful practices. However I am convinced that the thing that keeps most Christians from “PURSUING” God is their inability to escape the perimeters and boundaries, that they themselves have set for God’s Spirit. These boundaries are traditions that they have come under bondage to, beyond which they have chosen not to “PURSUE” God!

Most Christians, preachers and laity alike, give enormous amounts of lip service to the fact that they “DESIRE” the things of God more than anything else. It matters little how much lip service we give “THE PROOF OF DESIRE IS PURSUIT”!!!

In Colossians chapter three we are told that if we are going to “PURSUE” God there are at least three things we are going to have to do;

First of all we are told that we must “Set our affection on things above, not on things on the earth”. The church has suffered spiritual famine over the past couple of decades because we have allowed our attention to be diverted from our cause (PURSUING GOD), to a “PURSUIT” of the world and the things of the world. As a result we have become as carnal as a canary and cannot for the life of us figure out why God is not moving like he used to! The setting of your affection is not something God is going to do for you, it’s something you have been commanded to do on your own, if you are going to “PURSUE” God!

Secondly, we are told to “Seek those things which are above”! Let me ask you some questions that might help you determine what you are really seeking: Would you rather pray, or visit with your friends? Would you rather read your Bible, or watch television? Would you rather go to church, or go to a ballgame? Would you rather pay your tithes, or pay your car payment? Would you rather speak in tongues, or speak in English? Would you rather forgive someone who has wronged you, or hold a grudge? You see seeking God is more than just saying “Jesus I want you to be Lord of my life”. Seeking God is a 24 hour a day, seven day a week “PURSUIT” of God and his righteousness!

Thirdly, the Scripture says “When Christ, who is your life, shall appear, then shall ye also appear with him in Glory”. Need I remind you, that when you set your affection where it is supposed to be, and you seek God with a whole heart, Christ will appear in your life. (In every area of it!) When he appears you will soar with him! You will soar with him in the here and now by walking in the Spirit! You will also soar with him when he comes in the clouds of Heaven! There is a bumper sticker that has come out of the Pensacola Revival that makes the statement “YES LORD, WE WILL RIDE!” I think it might be better stated, “YES LORD, WE WILL SOAR!” I leave you with the following Scripture:

Psalm 42:1 "As the deer pants for streams of water,
so my soul pants for you, O God." Now friends that sounds like an all out
"PURSUIT" of God, thus proving his "DESIRE"!

PREPARING FOR THE WORK!

Nehemiah 2:11-20

There are times in history when a person or a group of people have made accomplishments that are so extraordinary that it is almost impossible to erase their accomplishments from our memories. There have been many of those kinds of people who have served the Lord in this church.

Nehemiah is one of those "GREAT MEN" whose footprints have been left deep and distinct on the sands of the past. In fact, his footprints have inspired with fresh courage the hearts of those suffering from illness and fatigue in the service of the Lord.

In this article I would like to look at the process that Nehemiah passed through in "PREPARING FOR THE WORK" to which God had called him. Hopefully, through his example we can find courage to accomplish Gods purposes right here in Malvern!

NEHEMIAH TOOK TIME FOR REFLECTION! Nehemiah 2:11

Through reflection we learn;

- 1) Not to repeat the mistakes of the past.
- 2) Repeat the successes of the past, with greater intensity.
- 3) Make sure the future is more effective than the past.

NEHEMIAH SURVEYED THE DIFFICULTIES! Nehemiah 2:12-13

Many Christians live in a fool's paradise because they refuse to believe that there can be any difficulties, as long as they are in the will of God! Tell that to - Noah - The three Hebrew children - Daniel - Paul - etc...

Jesus never promised an easy road to success, he just promised that the man who counted the cost before building a house would have what it takes to finish it!

NEHEMIAH MAKES AN APPEAL FOR WORKERS! Nehemiah 2:17

Please notice that Nehemiah did not say "go and build", but "come let us build".

The work God has called us to will require me and you to become absolutely committed with our prayers, finances, efforts, and tolerance.

NEHEMIAH WORKED IN SPITE OF THE OPPOSITION! Nehemiah 2:10, 2:19, 4:1-3

The more closely you try to follow the will of God, the more bitter the opposition will become. Need I remind you, the world and the religious crowd hated Jesus, and the

servant is not greater than his Lord!

When facing opposition, Nehemiah finally took a weapon in one hand, and a tool in the other, in order to accomplish the work.

The following is what I believe we need to focus on in the coming year;
Build a new sanctuary on the property we have purchased on Tanner Street. Because of this you are going to hear more about fundraising efforts with regard to this project than you have in the past.

The 32 acres of property on Tanner Street was purchased in March of 1997 for \$350,000.00. To date we have paid \$150,000.00 plus interest on this indebtedness. We now owe something less than \$200,000.00 on the property.

Our goals for the year of 2000;

- 1) Pay the property off as quickly as possible.
- 2) Begin construction of a new sanctuary.
- 3) Begin construction of a new office complex.

Our long-term goals would be as follows, and in this order;

- 1) Remodel present sanctuary and basement to accommodate a gymnasium.
- 2) Build an educational building, ballfields, and a walking trail around new property.

The way I hope to accomplish these goals;

- 1) Establish a fundraising committee that would focus on major fundraising efforts, targeted outside the church.
- 2) Call the people of the church to a time of very seriously considering what each individual will be able to do on a monthly basis.
- 3) Pray, and expect God to give us several large financial miracles.
- 4) Finish the project debt free!

Nehemiah lets us know that the only way the work of rebuilding the city of Jerusalem could possibly be accomplished was for the people to make up their mind to involve themselves in the project, and for God to anoint their efforts. Nehemiah's efforts, nor ours will be successful if both of these things do not happen!

Some folks think we can just sit around and expect God to come through with a miracle, but we must do what we can, and expect him to anoint our efforts. When we do this we open the door to a miracle of God!

Will you join me immediately in praying and asking God what he would have you to do?

During this season each year as we approach Christmas and the new year people begin making new years resolutions. While their resolutions are based on good intentions, most of the time find that they are falling short of the goals they have because they lack the committment to follow through.

This new year promises to be special because of the turn of the century. Much to do has been made over what is going to happen between December 31, 1999 and January 1, 2,000. I suppose everyone has heard about Y2K and has formed an opinion on what is going to transpire. Opinions range from the new year being the end of the world, to a lot of to do over nothing. Because of a saturation of media hype concerning Y2K this new years season will probably generate more new years resolutions than any other new year ever.

I am not well enough informed to make a lot of predictions about what the new century is going to bring in terms of politics or finances. However I do believe that God is doing a new thing in our world. There are people who believe that God cannot do new things, that he is limited to the recycling business. You don't have to be a scholar to figure out that the Word of God say's that God will do many things that are new:

- We are partakers of a New Birth - 2 Cor:5:17 The New Birth alone finds it's expression in new growth, new knowledge, new fruitfulness, new victory and new discipline!
- We have a New Covenant - Jer. 31:31
- We have a New Name - Isaiah 62:2
- We have been given a New Spirit - Ezekiel 11:19
- We have been given a New Commandment - John 13:34
- We will bear New Fruit - Ezekiel 47:12
- God will create a New Heaven and a New Earth - Isaiah 66:22, Isaiah 65:17

Just because God is doing a New Thing does not mean that he has abandoned all the old things. As we approach the next century we need to pray that God will inhance and increase some of the things that we have come to expect from Him:

- Increased safety and protection - Deut. 33:12, 33:29

- Increased strength - Deut. 33:25
- Increased support - Deut. 33:27
- Increased favor - Deut. 33:23
- Increased momentum - Deut. 28:6
- Increased blessings - Deut. 28:8

My prayer for you and your family is that God will richly bless you and your family in every thing that you set your hand to do. May the year 2,000 be the very best you have ever experienced!

GOALS

1.1 Enroll each new convert in a prescribed course of study (New converts class), to help them with their new life in Christ.

1.2 Involve each new convert in a home fellowship group so they will develop relationships that will aid them in their new life in Christ.

1.3 Upon completion of the new converts course, all new converts will be strongly encouraged to enroll in discipleship training beginning with a gifts and ministries class. This class will be aimed at helping them to discover and use their God-given talents, within the context of the church family.

1.4 Upon completion of the gifts and ministries class, each new convert will be expected to find a place to serve the Lord and the church. They will also be strongly encouraged to pursue discipleship courses as they are available.

2.1 Become a monthly supporter of R.O.S.E. to help meet the food and clothing needs of our community.

2.2 Participate in “Neighborhood Cover” doing yard work, light repair jobs, painting, etc... expecting nothing in return.

2.3 Become a clear voice in support of decency and righteousness in line with the vision of our country’s founding fathers. Regardless of political affiliation, be an avid supporter of those who run for political office who espouse these principles.

2.4 Organize, promote, and fund an “Operation Hope” outreach within this community.

3.1 Provide a greeters ministry that is gifted, trained and professional in dealing with new comers.

3.2 Train the church body to provide a pleasant atmosphere for newcomers.

3.3 Develop an “Adopt-A-Family” ministry within our church.

3.4 Immediately discover what kind of ministry the newcomer is in need of, and point

them in a proper direction. Find out where they would like to involve themselves, and make a place for them to serve.

4.1 Find missions projects that will appeal to our congregation, and take on one or more of them per year.

5.1 Develop a discipleship program for all ages.

5.2 Develop a curriculum committee that will be charged with the responsibility of screening all materials, before they are offered.

5.3 Develop, train and place people in ministry accordant to their comfort zone.

6.1 Use curriculum for which students can receive transferable college credit.

6.2 Set a good example before the students in the area of righteousness, Godliness, lifestyle, work ethic, etc..

6.3 Deliver the kind of product that will cause people to seek us out when searching for young people for full-time ministry.

7.1 Develop leaders within the church, through discipleship training.

7.2 Allow only those people to serve in leadership positions who are willing to submit themselves to be trained.

8.1 Provide regular worship services. (Sun. am & pm, wed. nights)

8.2 Provide revival services several times a year.

8.3 Be balanced in our worship, realizing God is a God of variety, and we are a very diverse group of people with a very wide range of likes, and dis-likes.

9.1 Introduce First Assembly to every resident in the 72104 Zip Code. Knock on every door in this Zip Code.

9.2 Teach lifestyle evangelism to our Church family. Challenge each family to bring at least one new family into the church each year.

9.3 Promote evangelism through our television ministry. Within the next five years have a program that airs at least statewide.

9.4 Encourage everyone who preaches and teaches to be intentionally evangelistic, giving altar calls aimed at those who are lost or backslidden.

10.1 Develop a first class Christian academy through the 12th grade, that can be embraced by the entire community.

10.2 Become a satellite campus for Southwestern or CBC.

10.3 Offer Berean classes on an ongoing basis.

11.1 Provide strong preaching and teaching outlining the necessity and blessings attached to Christian finance.

11.2 Be diligent to explain to all new members that the church expects them to be faithful with their tithes and offerings.

11.3 Be diligent to explain to all new converts that the church expects them to be faithful with their tithes and offerings.

12.1 Build a new sanctuary that will seat approximately 1200 people.

12.2 Build an educational building that will provide for the discipleship needs of all who attend our church.

12.3 Renovate present facilities to include a Youth Center, the Christian Academy, satellite school for college level courses, classroom space for Berean students, and Master's Commission training.

Dear Campground Supporter:

Springtime is upon us! Out of the dead of winter new life is springing forth! Winter is a difficult time for many reasons, but spring makes us feel as though we have a new lease on life.

We have tried to turn the worst time of the year into the most productive time of the year. I am glad to report to you that many things have been accomplished during the fall and winter of this year. The Mini Storage Facility has been completed, and is now in the process of filling up with renters. The old swimming pool area has been cleaned out to make way for a pond for fishing and paddle boats. Plans have been developed to construct a new 1500 seat sanctuary. (See enclosed floor plan and elevation drawing.) The enclosed drawings are very preliminary, and are subject to change. All we need to get started is MONEY! We are presently negotiating with Weyerhaeuser to purchase additional adjoining property for future development. We have also learned that grants are available from Weyerhaeuser through employees who attend Assemblies of God churches and use our retreat facilities.

You can be of assistance in the following ways;

- Send the best gift possible during the month of March!
- Make sure your church is a regular monthly supporter of Mountain Valley Retreat Center!
- Receive a special offering in your church for Mountain Valley Retreat Center and bring it to District Council. (May 15-17)
- If you, or anyone you are acquainted with (Must be a person who attends an Assemblies of God church), is employed by Weyerhaeuser, please complete the enclosed form and return it to the address specified! (Please feel free to duplicate as needed)
- Pray for all meetings conducted on these grounds, that there would be an awesome awareness of the presence of Jesus.

Thank you for your faithful support in times past. These accomplishments could not have happened without you. Please know that we need to hear from you very soon!

In HIS Service

I would like to take this opportunity to share with you some information that the Church Board and I are very excited about. As you know we are in the process of paying off the indebtedness on the new church property located on Tanner Street. The indebtedness currently stands at \$_____. Our goals for this process include;

- Be financially responsible, by paying for the current project before beginning another.
- Take steps necessary to keep the church body informed of the progress.
- Complete the process of working with the Architects, while the property is being paid for.
- Present a completely functional and affordable plan to the church body for approval.

In keeping with these goals the following information is being submitted for your perusal.

FRONT VIEW OF CHURCH BUILDING

SIDE VIEW OF CHURCH BUILDING

FLOOR PLAN - SANCTUARY LEVEL

The main floor of the sanctuary will seat 730. The choir loft will seat 128. The balcony will seat 422. Further information will be shared in the Sunday morning service on May 14th. If you have questions or suggestions please do not hesitate to contact me.

In HIS service

Rev. Don Nordin

I THINK MYSELF HAPPY!

In the Twenty Sixth chapter of the book of Acts we find the Apostle Paul standing before Agrippa about to answer questions concerning his behavior within the religious community. He has been accused of all kinds of blasphemous acts when in reality there was absolutely no evidence to support the charges!

Paul has been arrested and tried by the legal religious authorities of his day, and because no one can find anything within his character worthy of prison or death, they pass him around like a political hot potato!

While Paul was in Ephesus for his final time he spoke of his incarceration in this manner: [Acts 20:22-23](#) "And now, behold, I go bound in the spirit unto Jerusalem, not knowing the things that shall befall me there: ²³Save that the Holy Ghost witnesseth in every city, saying that bonds and afflictions abide me."

Paul had every opportunity to become angry, and develop a sour attitude, but listen to what he continues to say: [Acts 20:24](#) "But none of these things move me, neither count I my life dear unto myself, so that I might finish my course with joy, and the ministry, which I have received of the Lord Jesus, to testify the gospel of the grace of God."

How could he possibly maintain an attitude of victory in such a turbulent time in his life? I believe he let us in on the secret to his attitude of victory even though he knew he was staring death in the whites of the eyes. Listen to the first Four words he says to Agrippa, [Acts 26:2](#) "I think myself happy..."

Now please understand that I am aware that Paul was saying to Agrippa that he was happy for the opportunity to finally tell his side of the story. However I believe that those Four words characterize the life and ministry of the Apostle Paul! He had Pastored and preached in places where he had to "THINK HIMSELF HAPPY" in order to continue on!

Paul practiced "THINKING HIMSELF HAPPY" to the point that he was able to say, [Philip. 4:11](#) "... I have learned, in whatsoever state I am, *therewith* to be content."

How could this be? I believe he told us how Three versus earlier: [Philip. 4:8](#) "Finally, brethren, whatsoever things are true, whatsoever things are honest, whatsoever things are just, whatsoever things are pure, whatsoever things are lovely, whatsoever things are of good report; if *there be* any virtue, and if *there be* any praise, think on these things."

I can tell you that in your marriage, relationships, employment, and spiritual walk you will either “THINK YOURSELF” happy or sad!

I choose by an act of my own will to “THINK MYSELF HAPPY”!!! Are you going to overflow with joy and be pleasant to be around, or are you going to be a sad sack that everyone dreads having to spend time with?

The decision is yours! “THINK YOURSELF HAPPY” for all of our sakes!!!

Dear _____ :

As you are aware, we are in the process of retiring the debt on the new church property; working with the architects to complete a master plan for construction of a new building; and preparing for a target date for construction to begin on a much needed facility here at First Assembly.

One of the steps that we must take to bring us closer to reaching our goal is to prepare for a capital stewardship campaign that will begin on September 17th and end on October 15th. I am attempting to assemble a steering committee that would have the oversight of this most important task. I am asking you to serve as ----- . I would like for you to examine the enclosed job description and decide whether you can serve in this capacity. I need to hear from you immediately with regard to this assignment. (The deadline is Wednesday June 28, 2000.)

If you agree to accept this assignment you must be willing to give it your very best effort. Our consultant for this campaign will be Rev. Larry Russell from Springfield Mo., and he will train you in your area of responsibility. My staff and I will be carrying a very heavy load as it relates to this campaign so it is imperative that you fulfill your job description as independently as possible.

I am looking forward to hearing a positive word from you in the next couple of days regarding this assignment. Remember, ***“We are laborers together with God”!***

In HIS service

Case statement

Malvern First Assembly Of God
“Praise For The Past, Faith For The Future”
Capital Stewardship Campaign

The leadership of Malvern First Assembly Of God believes that God is taking us to a new level in our spiritual journey together. We the pastoral staff, deacons and trustees, as well as you, the congregation have been praying for God's perfect will for this church and we believe it is time for us to take a significant step forward. This church, and all of its previous facilities was built by people who had a vision larger than what they could see with their natural eye. Each building that has been constructed was larger than what was needed at the time. That is because they were preparing a place for all of us! We are thankful that in the history of this church the leadership had enough foresight and faith to prepare for those of us who would arrive at a later time. We must rise to the challenge and take a bold step of faith in preparing for those who will follow us into the kingdom of God. We ***“Praise God For The Past”*** and everyone who has contributed to its success.

To meet this challenge, we are intentionally entering into one of the most significant periods in the history of this great church. Because of the magnitude of this challenge, each person in our congregation will be asked to pray about a three year sacrificial commitment over and above their tithes. This will enable us to construct a much needed new facility in a new location and renovate our existing facilities for a private Christian school, and master's commission facility. It will take great faith for us to meet the challenge laid before us, but this is our hour and God is with us in this exciting venture of faith. Together we have ***“Faith For The Future”***.

The summer months have certainly brought about a number of unexpected staff changes here at First Assembly. The following changes have been made;

- Bro. Branson submitted his resignation as Associate Pastor having accepted the

pastorate of First Assembly of God in McDonough Georgia.

- Jeff Ballew resigned as director of Malvern Master's Commission to pursue other areas that he believes God is leading him into.
- John Pennington resigned as Children's Pastor to become involved with Book Of Hope International.
- Gary Housenga resigned as youth pastor to return to his home in Bettendorf Iowa.

I would like to take this opportunity to commend each of these gentlemen for their contribution to the continuing success of Malvern First Assembly of God church. Through their ministry to each of us, these gentlemen and their families, have added a very distinct flavor of ministry into the mix of making this church what it has become. The influence they have had will no doubt be with us long after they are gone.

I want to say to each of these fine brothers, as well as to their families, we love you and wish you the very best that God has to offer in your new field of labor. Our prayer for you is: "The Lord bless you and keep you; ²⁵the Lord make his face shine upon you and be gracious to you; ²⁶the Lord turn his face toward you and give you peace." Numbers 6:24-26

As of the writing of this article only two of these staff positions have been filled. They are as follows;

INTERIM YOUTH PASTOR: Jason and Celeste Amerson will be Interim Youth Pastor's until we can find a full time person to fill the vacancy. As most of you know, Jason was raised here in First Assembly, he is the son of Charles and Betty Amerson. Jason attended Master's Commission at Evangel Temple in Fort Smith Arkansas. Following his graduation from Master's Commission he went on to be the Children's Pastor, and then Youth Pastor at Evangel Temple. Jason is married to Celeste Hutchings Amerson. (Her father and mother Rev. and Mrs. Don Hutchings pastor Evangel Temple in Fort Smith Arkansas.) Celeste has been involved in church work her entire life, having served in various capacities in children's ministry and youth ministry. The Amerson's will no doubt be an asset to this staff. Will you join me in making them feel welcome?

MASTER'S COMMISSION DIRECTOR: Carlos and Libby Ortiz will be joining our staff as Master's Commission Directors July 2, 2000. Carlos and Libby come to us from Dallas Texas where Carlos has served as the administrator of the Dallas Masters Commission for the past five years. Carlos has a Bachelor's degree from Southwestern Assemblies of God University. His major was church business administration. Libby is originally from Cedar Rapids, Iowa, and is a Master's Commission graduate. Over the past several years Libby has been heavily involved in Sunday School, Children's ministry, daycare, and drama. These people will no doubt be an asset to this staff. Will you join me in making them feel welcome?

Please continue to pray for supernatural direction with regard to the other staff vacancies.

We love you and you are constantly in our prayers.

Pastor, Susan, and family.

It is very difficult for me to imagine, but more than half of the year 2000 is already history. How time fly's when you're having fun! (Or maybe I'm just getting older?)

With the passing of this calendar year we have seen a significant decrease in the amount of the indebtedness on the new church property, located on Tanner Street. We now owe

approximately \$100,000.00. The reduction in principal on this loan since the beginning of the year presently stands at \$106,405.60. As a result the people of First Assembly have made a significant move toward being able to proceed with the construction of new facilities.

I want to take the space I have been allotted in this newsletter to talk about what you can expect in the coming months with regard to the building project.

First, we need you to continue being faithful with your monthly giving to this project. We will not do anything as far as construction is concerned until the property note has been paid in full.

Second, during the month of August we hope to schedule a special called business meeting for the purpose of presenting building plans and ideas for future expansion. The church body will be asked to ballot on the plans presented by the Official Board of the church.

Third, in an effort to raise the funds necessary to build the first phase of the new building, a steering committee will be introduced to guide a Capital Stewardship Campaign. You may be called upon to serve on one of these committees, if so, remember we must all participate if we are going to bring this project to a successful conclusion.

Fourth, you will eventually be called upon to make a three year commitment to this Campaign. Your commitment will need to be ***over and above*** your normal giving. I have had people ask me, “do you believe asking people to make an ***over and above*** commitment is a good thing to do”? I will attempt to answer in the following way: This is certainly a scriptural practice for building a place of worship. I challenge you to read 1 Chronicles 29. David is preparing for the building of the Temple which his son Solomon will erect. A number of things you will discover in this chapter will include:

- David gave of his personal treasures to God. Vs. 3
- His gift was ***over and above*** everything else he was already giving. Vs. 3
- The officers, and heads of households gave willingly. Vs. 6
- The people rejoiced because of the willing, free, and wholehearted response of their leaders. Vs. 9
- The people gave. Vs. 14
- They were aware that the ability to give was originally from God. Vs. 14
- They were aware that all of their possessions really belongs to God. Vs. 16

Over and above giving means that we do not take tithe or missions giving to give to the Stewardship Campaign.

Solomon’s Temple was built with ***over and above*** income, and this building must built the same way!

Will you begin praying about what God would have you to do with regard to this very crucial need?

I believe God is calling First Assembly to enlarge the borders of it's tent, not for better or more impressive buildings, but that we would enhance our ability to minister more effectively to this entire region. Will you help us?

We want you to know that you are loved!

Pastor, Susan, and family!

PRAISE FOR THE PAST, FAITH FOR THE FUTURE

Not Equal Giving, But Equal Sacrifice

From The Pastor

We are entering the first Capital Stewardship Campaign ever attempted here at First Assembly, using a professional Stewardship company. A number of months ago The

Church Board and I commissioned a fundraising committee made up of a Board member and a cross-section of lay-members and lay-leadership. Out of that committee came the recommendation to proceed with our fundraising efforts using Church Stewardship Services, who is a part of the Assemblies of God Financial Group based in Springfield Missouri. Our consultant for this campaign will be Rev. Larry Russell. Rev. Russell is an ordained Assemblies Of God Minister and an experienced church stewardship consultant. He is committed to helping First Assembly Of God follow the principles of biblical giving. He knows how to lead a successful campaign and do it well.

We are embarking upon the most significant period in the history of this great church. Malvern First Assembly has a very rich history, including:

- Predating the Assemblies Of God by five years - It had it's beginning in 1909.
- The First General Superintendent of the Assemblies Of God was pastoring this church when elected to this prestigious and historic office - Rev. E. N. Bell.
- The first copy of the Word And Witness magazine was printed here - Later becoming the Pentecostal Evangel.
- Many great Pastors and lay people have served this church over it's 91 year history.

That's why today we give ***Praise For The Past***. The history of this church is certainly extremely important, but the reason the past has been so great is because there were leaders who dreamed bigger dreams than they could see with their natural eye, thus blazing the trail and making room for those who would follow after them. They not only dreamed big dreams, but sacrificed to see those dreams become a reality. Will you join me in giving ***Praise For The Past***?

Now it's our turn. We must take up the mantle of faith and spiritual growth that has been left to us by our forefathers, and have ***Faith For The Future!*** In having ***Faith For The Future*** we must also be willing to sacrifice for the sake of those who will follow us into the kingdom of God.

Do we have what it takes to take a bold step into the future? In the next few weeks each of us will be called upon to answer this all important question. I have compiled a list of things we must do in order to say we will do what is necessary to take this bold step into the future:

- Pray that everything we do will be consistent with what God would want for each of us individually, and as a corporate body of believers!
- Pray for faith and boldness. That every person in this church will be willing to stretch their faith to new limits!
- When making your commitment have faith that God will provide! If you can see exactly how you are going to fulfil your faith promise, it is not a faith promise at all! A faith promise is a step of faith that you can only fulfil if God get's involved!
- When you are asked to participate, step forward and say "YES"!
- Pray that God will find the people of First Assembly faithful to the vision He has placed among us!

While we offer ***Praise For The Past*** let us rise to the challenge and have

Faith For The Future!

Our ***Praise For The Past, Faith For The Future*** Stewardship Campaign is now in full swing. I am very excited about what I am seeing God perform in and through the people of First Assembly. I trust you are praying fervently for the success of this campaign. As you pray, I am asking you to come into agreement with me on the following things:

- that the leadership will make proper decisions.
- that the resources necessary for the construction of these facilities will come into the hands of the people of First Assembly.
- that the people of First Assembly will be generous in releasing the resources to the lord of the church.

- that construction costs will fall short of projections.
- that the project will be completed debt free.

In the coming weeks the following things will be occurring:

- A Leadership Commitment Event will be held at the Malvern High School Cafeteria on October 7th at 6:00 PM. I have intentionally invited the leadership of First Assembly to be present at this event. Throughout the Word of God leadership is always instructed to take the first step, and the leadership of this church will do no less. A preliminary commitment will be taken from each family present. If you did not receive an invitation to this event but would like to attend, I would welcome you to be a part of this very important meeting. You can make reservations by calling the church office and speaking to Susan.
- Sunday October fifteenth will feature the main event of this campaign. The location for this event will be the new church property, located on Tanner Street, behind Wal-Mart. On this particular Sunday there will be no Sunday School, or evening service. Everyone (Babies, children, youth and adults) will be worshipping under a large gospel tent (That is the way First Assembly began in 1909.). We will be having a church-wide potluck dinner that will follow the morning service. On this particular morning we will be asking every family to make a faith promise to this campaign. Your faith promise will be payable over the next three years.

Please remember there are many ways to give:

- You can give a one time lump-sum gift!
- You can give through weekly, monthly or annual contributions.
- You can give property, securities, or other assets.
- You can give by donating labor or other skills needed during the building process. (Refer to the 10 ways to give brochure that you have been provided.)

As I bring this article to a close, let me remind you that those who have gone before us made sacrifices that affected their life and livelihood, so that you and I could have a proper place to worship and serve God. It has come time for us to step up to the plate and do our part. Will we pass the test, or will we allow their dream to die on our watch? I am thankful for the past, but I possess a great deal of faith that the people of First Assembly will rise to the challenge and provide something better for the future!!!

Pastor, Susan, Jason & Larissa

We have just recently concluded our ***Praise For The Past, Faith For The Future*** Capital Stewardship Campaign. The results prove what all of us have been aware of for a very long time:

God is on our side. He is still in the miracle business.

The people of First Assembly are BIG hearted.

The people of First Assembly are generous givers.

I want to thank you for your three year commitment toward this very worthy project. The Scripture tells us that great things can be accomplished when the body of Christ works together in unity and harmony. I am expecting this thing to be accomplished ahead of schedule.

There are four additional things I want to address in this article:

- I trust all of you are aware that Wednesday night services have recently resumed. (All Services begin at 7:00 PM) The options for adult services are as follows; A services is being conducted by Bro. Keith Pennington in the hospitality room, with praise and worship and preaching of the Word. I am teaching a course (Through the Bible in 52 weeks) in a classroom located in the basement of the sanctuary building.
- Also on Wednesday evenings, we have Supergang, JBQ, and Yoth services for your children and youth. I want to encourage you to get your children involved in these very effective ministries.
- Saturday evening prayer meeting is currently being held in the Sanctuary from 5:00 - 6:00 PM. I believe corporate prayer is a must for the church that plans to be effective in reaching it's community. I would strongly encourage everyone to set aside this time to prepare themselves for what the Holy Spirit wants to do for us, and through us on Sunday. Remember, the church that prays together, stays together!
- Your 2000 missions commitments need to be in the church office no later than Sunday, December 10th. The reason for this deadline is that the General Council has set December 15th as a deadline for crediting contributions for the year. This will give our bookkeeping department adequate time to process your giving and send it to Springfield before the deadline.

The book of Hebrews is one of my favorite books in the Bible. This Epistle is loaded with tremendous nuggets of spiritual truth that can be adapted to everyday twenty-first century life. I have recently been reading in the book of Hebrews in my private devotions. As usual I began to notice some things I have never noticed before. The sixth chapter began to come alive to me, and I want to look at it with you in this article. There are three things I want us to focus our thoughts on today; Good Works; Hope; Faith & Patience:

Good Works: **Hebrews 6:10** "God is not unjust; he will not forget your work and the love you have shown him as you have helped his people and continue to help them." When someone blesses us in some way, we try to find a way to show our gratitude. When someone blesses our children, we are more grateful than we would have been if they had blessed us. The writer here is saying that God will bless those who bless his children This

is a promise as old as Abraham. God said "I will bless them that bless you, I will curse them that curse you." If you want the blessing of God, find a way to bless one of his children. If you have done your part to bless God's children, wait patiently because God has a plan in the works to bless you! If, on the other hand, you have been involved in tearing down God's family you will no doubt receive punishment if there is no repentance and restitution. Believe me, I would much rather be found blessing God's family, rather than fighting his family.

Hope: Verse 11 talks about "...Hope to the end." Then Verse 18 says that "...We might have strong consolation, having fled for refuge to lay hold of the Hope set before us." Verse 19 says "Hope is the anchor of the soul, sure and steadfast, and takes us behind the veil." What is this Hope? The word Hope comes from the Greek word Elpis, and means confidence. What confidence is capable of anchoring our soul's (Mind, will & emotions) in the midst of life's storms? Confidence that the blood of Jesus is enough to cover all of our sin's, past, present & future! Confidence in His ability to keep us in the here and now! Confidence in His ability and willingness to meet all my needs! Confidence in His soon return!

It is possible to be involved in Good Works, and have your Confidence rightly directed and still never be able to get to the place in God that you feel your prayers are going to be answered. **Hebrews 6:12** "We do not want you to become lazy, but to imitate those who through faith and patience inherit what has been promised." We are strongly admonished here to follow the example of Faith and Patience set by those who obtained promises. Speaking of Abraham **Hebrews 6:15** says "And so after waiting patiently, Abraham received what was promised."

Can you believe it? Winter is in full swing, the trees and landscape are dead, the weather leaves much to be desired, the year 2000 has come to a conclusion, and 2001 is about to begin. Even though most of us do not like winter, we patiently endure it because we know spring is just around the corner, and with spring there will be **"A NEW BEGINNING"**. The year 2001 is the beginning of the twenty first century. It is my opinion that as a church we should look upon this year as **"A NEW BEGINNING"**.

God's word is full of examples of people who were afforded the opportunity for **"A NEW BEGINNING"**. After more than 400 years of slavery in Egypt, Israel was given a new lease on life in the form of **"A NEW BEGINNING"**. **Exodus 12:1-2** ***"And the Lord spake unto Moses and Aaron in the land of Egypt, saying, 'This month shall be unto you the beginning of months: it shall be the first month of the year to you.'***

In order to bring this “**NEW BEGINNING**” about for the Israelites, God sets a bush on fire in the desert and speaks to a senior citizen by the name of Moses to lead them from Egypt to Caanan. For Israel the visitation of the death angel meant the “**BEGINNING**” of a new epoch, a new era, this would be a new starting point. God is no respecter of persons, what he did for Israel, he will do for you and I! **Isaiah 43:19** “*Behold, I will do a new thing; now it shall spring forth; shall ye not know it? I will even make a way in the wilderness, and rivers in the desert.*”

If you were to research the history of Israel, you would find a path strewn with the wreckage of centuries of exile and servitude. For Israel this “**NEW BEGINNING**” was to be an emancipation, a redemption, an exodus! I’m quite sure that many of the Israelites wondered if they would ever be able to completely shake the monkey of enslavement and servitude, and experience “**A NEW BEGINNING**”. The answer to that question is that God would provide the grace and tools necessary for them to live free from the past, but the real test would be whether they would do what was necessary to facilitate this “**NEW BEGINNING**”.

God desires the same for us! He wants to wipe the slate clean, forgive the past, and make bright the future! The real question is, can you forget the past and by faith lay hold of the future? As with Israel, repentance and forgiveness are the foundational stones upon which “**A NEW BEGINNING**” is built. To repent means to say you are sorry for the wrong you have done, and make a firm commitment never to repeat the action. To forgive is to allow God by the power of his Holy Spirit to take the pain out of a past experience, to the point that you have no desire to even the score. If you truly desire to have “**A NEW BEGINNING**” you must firmly plant your spiritual feet upon these two foundational stones.

Responsibility comes with “**A NEW BEGINNING**”. When Israel left Egypt they were confronted with the hardships of the wilderness, and finally with the responsibility of driving the giants out of Caanan. There comes a time for those who have experienced “**A NEW BEGINNING**” to be schooled and disciplined by processes that are less than desirable. It is in these difficult times that the characteristics of our Heavenly Father are developed within us. These processes cannot be hurried, rather patiently and faithfully endured. I believe that the year of 2000, as difficult as it was, has set the stage for God to do a new thing within this church. I can hardly wait to see what God is going to accomplish in 2001 as we prepare for “**A NEW BEGINNING**”!

The national events of the past month have no doubt shaken all of us somewhat. Without question Tuesday, September 11th, 2001 will go down in the history books as one of the darkest day's in United States history. Before that day none of us would have believed such hideous things could occur within the borders of this nation.

As a result of this tragedy we have seen quite a number of positive things happening that probably would not have happened;
Bipartisan politics in Washington DC. The politicians have forsaken their own personal agenda, and are pursuing an agenda that is driven by what is good for the people.

People are pulling together as never before. The theme all across America seems to be, "What can I do to help"! Following this tragedy I called officials in the New York City area to offer to bring a group of people to aid in the clean-up effort, and was told that they had more help than they could manage now!

Public praying and quoting of Scripture is being spoken out over the airwaves in a manner that we have not seen in many years. (And no one seems to mind!)

Fox News reported that on Sunday, September 16th, 2001, Synagogues and houses of worship were “stacked to the rafters”.

This is certainly not an exhaustive list of positive things that have come from such a terrible turn of events, but some good things are beginning to surface in this nation. Never forget that God has a way of turning tragedy into triumph.

Someone asked me what the role of Christians should be in a time such as this? My answer was as follows:

I. REPENT OF PAST SINS!

Repentance is needed in America, from the church house to the state house to the schoolhouse. I believe that if America will repent, there will be national as well as worldwide revival. **2 Chron. 7:14** *"If my people, who are called by my name, will humble themselves and pray and seek my face and turn from their wicked ways, then will I hear from heaven and will forgive their sin and will heal their land."*

Repentance is more than just saying you are sorry, it is turning to walk in a different direction. If we will do what the Bible says we will receive the benefits it promises.

II. RESPOND TO PRESENT PROBLEMS!

There has never been a time when the opportunity to minister to the hurts and needs of people has been as great as it is right now. It seems as though these terrible events have caused people to become transparent. People are allowing their own problems, domestic, spiritual, and social to come to the surface possibly in the hopes that someone can help them. The question is will we be there for them, or will we allow the day of our visitation to pass us by? Jesus said, **Luke 4:18-19** *"The Spirit of the Lord is on me, because he has anointed me to preach good news to the poor. He has sent me to proclaim freedom for the prisoners and recovery of sight for the blind, to release the oppressed, ¹⁹to proclaim the year of the Lord's favor."*

Can we rise to the occasion and do what Jesus would do?

III. CLAIM THE PROMISES OF GOD!

In spite of all the pain, fear, and hurt, God's promises are as follows;

He will be with us always!

He will direct our path!

He will turn our mourning into dancing!

In times like these we need to stand on God's promises!

In the Fourth chapter of the book of Luke we are reminded that Jesus spent Forty days fasting and praying, and was afterward tempted of the devil. Following his triumph over the tempter Jesus returns to Nazareth and begins to teach in the synagogue.

Near the end of his teaching he makes what appears to be a strange comment regarding the widow of Zarephath, and Naaman the leper... [Luke 4:25-27](#)

The story of the widow of Zarephath can be found in the 1 Kings 17. Her conditions were as follows;

- Financially she is destitute! All she has in the house is a handful of meal in a barrel, and a little oil in a cruse!
- She and her son are about to cook what they have left in the house, and then they are going to die!
- She is asked by the Prophet of God to cook what she has and give it to him!

She obeys, and the Bible says she and her son were provided for throughout the Three and One Half years of famine!

Jesus also addresses the healing of Naaman the leper. Naamans story can be found in 2 Kings 5. Here is the story of Naaman;

- He was a leper!
- He came to Elisha seeking healing!
- He did not receive the treatment he thought he deserved!
- He wanted to go dip in a river other than the Jordan!
- He obeyed the words of Elisha, dipped Seven times in the Jordan River and was made whole of the disease of leprosy!

In our text Jesus said, there were many widows in Israel in Elija's day, but only one received provision! There were many lepers in Israel in Elisha's time, but only one received his healing! Why? **OBEDIENCE!**

The lesson for us is as follows: [Isaiah 1:19](#) ***"If you are willing and obedient, you will eat the best from the land;"***

Our Heavenly Father wants the very best for all of us! If we are willing to receive, and obedient to his instructions we will surely be blessed of the Lord!

I can hardly believe it is almost Christmas time again. Christmas should be one of the

most important holidays on the calendar of the Christian. Christmas has become so commercialized that many Christian people actually dread the season. It is my opinion that we need to put Christ back in Christmas, and allow his presence to be the center and circumference of everything that we do.

I am going to be doing something this year that I have never done since I have been pastoring. Through the month of December in each service I am going to be preaching on a Christmas theme. Our theme for the month will be **“CHRISTMAS LESSONS OF WORSHIP”**.

The second chapter of the book of Matthew is dedicated to describing the events surrounding the birth of Jesus. In this historical account of the first Christmas I believe we can find at least five **“CHRISTMAS LESSONS OF WORSHIP”**.

I. WORSHIP WILL TAKE YOU ON A SPIRITUAL JOURNEY! **Matthew 2:1-2** *"Now when Jesus was born in Bethlehem of Judaea in the days of Herod the king, behold, there came wise men from the east to Jerusalem. Saying, Where is he that is born King of the Jews? for we have seen his star in the east, and are come to worship him."*

We are not sure how far these wise men had to travel to get to Bethlehem to worship Jesus, but we must assume that they traveled a considerable distance. The worship of the wise men caused them to embark upon a journey. When you begin to enter into true worship it will take you on a journey. Jesus told the woman at the well of Samaria, **John 4:23** *"But the hour cometh, and now is, when the true worshippers shall worship the Father in spirit and in truth: for the Father seeketh such to worship him."*

When you begin to worship God in spirit and in truth, your worship will take you on a journey. This journey will take you from the camp of the living dead, into the very presence of God, where the joy of living can be found. Your worship will be the vehicle that transports you from where you are, to where God wants you to be.

II. WORSHIP WILL TAKE YOU OUT OF FAMILIAR SURROUNDINGS!

When you examine this story you will discover that every character involved, is outside their familiar surroundings including Mary, Joseph, and baby Jesus.

When you begin to embark upon a journey of worship, you will soon discover that you are being moved beyond your normal comfort zone. The end result of worship will cause us to sit together in heavenly places in Christ Jesus.

III. WORSHIP WILL BRING YOU TO YOUR KNEES AT THE FEET OF JESUS! **Matthew 2:11** *"And when they were come into the house, they saw the young child with Mary his mother, and fell down, and worshipped him:..."*

The wise men are accustomed to being approached by a King who is seeking advice. Now they find themselves on their knees, worshipping a newborn baby! Someone asked the question, "how many wise men came to worship Jesus?" The answer to that question is, "all of them"!

Our journey of worship will cause us to bow at his feet in worship!

IV. WORSHIP WILL CAUSE YOU TO GIVE YOUR VERY BEST! [Matthew 2:11](#) *"And when they were come into the house, they saw the young child with Mary his mother, and fell down, and worshipped him: and when they had opened their treasures, they presented unto him gifts; gold, frankincense, and myrrh."*

The level of worship that these people experienced, separated them from their most precious material goods. If you pursue a new level of worship your journey will likely find you offering him everything you possess. [Romans 12:1-2](#) *"I beseech you therefore, brethren, by the mercies of God, that ye present your bodies a living sacrifice, holy, acceptable unto God, which is your reasonable service. And be not conformed to this world: but be ye transformed by the renewing of your mind, that ye may prove what is that good, and acceptable, and perfect, will of God."*

V. WORSHIP WILL CAUSE YOU TO LEAVE ANOTHER WAY! [Matthew 2:12](#) *"And being warned of God in a dream that they should not return to Herod, they departed into their own country another way."*

Everyone who has ever embarked upon a journey of worship to the King, has always left another way! We were lost, but now we are found! We were blind, but now we can see! We have been translated from the kingdom of darkness into the kingdom of his dear Son!

When you worship Him in spirit and truth, you will leave another way!